2023 Baseball/Softball Rules Quiz

Force Outs/Timing Plays

- With bases loaded and no outs, the batter hits a sharp grounder to the 1st baseman who quickly tags her base and throws home to attempt to get the runner advancing from 3rd. The catcher, with his foot on home plate, catches the ball a full step before the runner crosses the plate. How many outs were recorded on the play?

One. The force out on the batter/runner at 1st counts as an out, of course, but that out removes the force on all other baserunners. Hence, the catcher had to *tag* the runner coming from 3rd to record another out.

- With the bases loaded and one out, the batter hits a long fly ball into center field. The center fielder catches it and throws back to the shortstop to double up the runner at 2nd to record the third out. Before the out was recorded at 2nd, the runner from 3rd crossed the plate (after tagging up). Does the run count?

Yes. This is considered a "timing play", as opposed to a "force out". If the 3rd out of an inning is a "force out", then no runs may score on the play. But this is not considered a "force out".

Fair or Foul?

- A low line drive travels over 3rd base and lands just beyond it in foul territory. Fair or foul?

Foul. If the ball *lands* in foul territory beyond the base, it is a foul ball. To be a fair ball, a ball crossing over 3rd base would have had to land *before* the base.

- A grounder with a lot of spin on it bounces along the 3rd base line (touching both foul territory and fair territory) and travels over the bag, coming to rest in foul territory. Fair or foul?

Fair. See above. A ball bouncing along -- *before* it reaches the base -- is fair if it travels over the base, or hits it.

- A fielder reaches into foul territory to field a bouncing ball. Both of the fielder's feet were in fair territory when he made contact with the ball. Fair or foul?

Foul. The only thing that matters on this call is where the ball was when the fielder made contact with it.

- A fielder making an attempt to catch a ball in fair territory boots the ball into foul territory. Fair or foul?

Fair. The reverse of the above. Because the fielder made first contact with the ball while it was in fair territory, it is a fair ball no matter where it came from or what happens from then on out. Ump should point into fair territory and watch the fun!

- The batter swings at a pitch, fouling it back to the catcher's mitt, but the catcher drops it. A runner at 1st, seeing the catcher drop the ball, takes off for 2nd and makes it. What, if anything, do you do?

Signal “foul!”. Ball is “dead”. Runner returns to 1st. Strike recorded on the batter unless it is third strike. In other words, it’s a foul ball.

- Same as above but the catcher catches the ball. What, if anything, do you do?

This is a “foul tip”. Treat it like a swinging strike. Batter is out if 3rd strike and ball is “live”. Runner can remain at 2nd unless that was the 3rd out of the inning.

- A pitch behind the batter strikes the bat accidentally as the batter was ducking out of the way (i.e., the batter did not swing). The ball rolls into fair territory. What, if anything, do you do?

Ball is considered to be “in play” (i.e., as if it was swung on and hit). Point into fair territory and watch the fun!

Interference/Obstruction

- A runner goes well outside the basepath to avoid an infielder who is awaiting a throw from an outfielder. The infielder catches the ball an instant later, then swoops around but misses the tag. The runner makes the next base safely. What, if anything, do you do?

Nothing. This is likely obstruction on the fielder because the runner had to avoid contact with a fielder who did not have the ball, but she made the base anyway, so no call is necessary. No harm, no foul.

- Same as above but the fielder successfully applies the tag on the runner. What, if anything, do you do?

This is likely obstruction on the fielder so you might consider awarding the base to the runner, but wait for the rest of the play to finish, then call "time" and sort things out.

- Same as above but the infielder is attempting to field a batted ball when the runner goes well outside the basepath to avoid contact with the fielder. The fielder throws out the runner. What, if anything, do you do?

Nothing. Out stands. A baserunner has the positive obligation to avoid contact with a fielder *making a play on a batted ball*. The baserunner is allowed some leeway to establish another basepath but this is not obstruction on the part of the fielder. The general principle is that a fielder making a play on a *batted* ball has absolute primacy on a potential interference/obstruction call. That is not necessarily the case on a *thrown* ball.

- Waiting for a throw from the shortstop on a batted ball, the 1st baseman stands on top of the bag. The batter/runner approaching 1st visibly slows down to avoid contact with the 1st baseman. The throw beats the runner but, in your judgment, had the batter/runner continued running at full speed to an empty base, he would have beat the throw. Do you award the batter/runner 1st base on obstruction?

The rules say you probably should. Standing on top of the base is obstructing the runner. And the baserunner is expected to avoid contact. On the other hand, the baserunner didn't even try to touch the base? Big time judgment call. Your best bet is to record the out but warn the managers that you may not be so

understanding next time. This is also why a safety base should be used at 1st in the younger divisions.

- The catcher fields a bunt out in front of the plate but does not attempt a throw to 1st because the batter/runner is running inside the 1st baseline (i.e., is not in the running lane) and would likely be struck by the catcher's throw. Is the batter/runner out on interference?

Runner is safe at 1st. In this specific situation, the catcher *must attempt a throw* to get the interference call.

- Same as above, but this time the catcher does attempt a throw and hits the runner in the back. The batter/runner reaches 1st safely. In addition, a runner who started the play at 2nd base reaches 3rd. What, if anything, do you do?

As soon as ball hits the batter/runner, call "time", call the batter/runner out and all runners need to return to their original base. This is interference, pure and simple. The runner is in safe harbor in his running lane, which they rarely run in, but not outside of it. Contrast that with a situation where a fielder throwing to another base hits a baserunner in the back (see above). That's a "play on" situation. The batter/runner attempting 1st is a specific exception to that rule.

- In an attempt to turn a double play, the shortstop steps on 2nd, but his throw to 1st hits the runner approaching 2nd. You don't believe the runner intentionally got in the way of the throw, nor that the fielder intentionally hit the runner. What, if anything, do you do?

This is another of those specifically-named situations. A runner put out on the bases is, for all intents and purposes, persona non grata. If she is struck by a thrown ball on a follow-on play, it is deemed interference and the other runner is out for the "sin of her teammate".

- Same as above except the shortstop eats the ball to avoid hitting the runner approaching from 1st. What, if anything, do you do?

This has been a matter of some debate. Umpire judgment is called for but seems like the fielder should have to *attempt* to get an out on the following runner to get the benefit of the interference out on that following runner. Likely a "play on" situation and the following runner is safe.

- A baserunner approaching 3rd base is hit in the back by a thrown ball coming in from right field and, as a result, reaches 3rd base. What, if anything, do you do?

Nothing. This is the opposite of the "batter/runner being out of the running lane" situation. That situation is a specific exception to the rule that a baserunner hit by a *thrown* ball is protected, provided he didn't do it intentionally. Contrast with the baserunner being hit by a *batted* ball.

- In what situations is a baserunner required to slide into a base to avoid interfering with a fielder?

Never. There is no such thing as a "must slide" rule. Never has been. Likely never will be. Baserunner should avoid contact with fielders and appeal to obstruction rules if their path is impeded. But how they avoid that contact is up to them. They do not have to slide to do so.

Hit By Pitch

- An inside pitch hits the batter on the hands gripping the bat as she's trying to get out of the way of the ball. Is she awarded 1st base on a hit-by-pitch?

Yes. The hands are not part of the bat. They are a part of the body, last we looked.

- An inside pitch hits the batter on the hands while he is swinging at the pitch. Is he awarded 1st base on a hit-by-pitch?

Because the hitter was swinging at the pitch, it is a strike and the batter is not awarded 1st on a hit-by-pitch. Doesn't matter where the hitter got hit. Only that the hitter was offering at the pitch.

- Same as the above but the batter is struck on the hands while *not* swinging. The hands were in the strike zone when the ball hit them. Is the batter awarded 1st base on a hit-by-pitch?

Similar to the above. If a body part – any body part – is struck while it is in the strike zone, then it's a strike. Batter is not awarded 1st.